



△ SKYE LANDSCAPE

Skye, Scotland's second largest island, boasts some dramatic landscapes. The large rock pinnacle at the center of this image is known as the Old Man of Storr.

The Scottish Highlands

A region of ancient mountains and extinct volcanoes, chiseled by glaciers and rainfall for many centuries, with a wild, rugged beauty



HOW THE CALEDONIAN MOUNTAINS FORMED

During the Caledonian Orogeny, tectonic movements caused ancient continents to collide and push up mountains. Later, the combined landmass broke up, leaving the mountains scattered across the North Atlantic region.



490-390 MILLION YEARS AGO



TODAY

The Scottish Highlands are part of the Caledonian Mountains—an ancient, much larger mountain chain that was formed in a series of events called the Caledonian Orogeny (see panel, left). They include the Northwest Highlands and the Grampians—which are separated by a 60-mile- (100-km-) long fault called the Great Glen Fault—as well as the mountainous islands of western Scotland. The Grampian Mountains are the highest in the British Isles, their tallest peak being Ben Nevis, at 4,413 ft (1,345 m).

Volcanic remnants

Scattered among the highlands are remnants of past volcanic activity. Ben Nevis was once a large volcano that collapsed in on itself following an eruption 350 million years ago. Some highland subranges, such as the Cairngorms, are made of granites formed from solidification of magma underground, later exposed by erosion. The highlands have a characteristic rugged appearance. Forest still covers some areas, providing a home to wildlife such as the capercaillie, pine marten, and wildcat.



Glen Coe, a valley in the Highlands, **was** once a **supervolcano**



◁△ HIGHLAND HEATHER

Heather is an emblem of Scotland. In late summer, purple heather clothes the lower slopes of the Scottish Highlands, where highland cattle can often be seen grazing.